



Glued to the action: India's players from (L-R) Shruti Mishra, Anmol Kharb and Tanvi Sharma watch P. V. Sindhu play against Thailand's Supanida Katethong at the 2024 Badminton Asia Team Championships. AFP

badminton of her career.

"I think after I beat the Chinese player, I got a lot of confidence in my ability. I've played better in this tournament because I was really patient during the rallies. I mostly played a lot of tosses and drops. I didn't hit a lot of smashes. I was really calm in this tournament. I think it was because of the team support and Gopi sir," she says.

However, Anmol admits there's a lot more she can improve on. "There was a moment in the semifinal (against Japan's Nidaira) where I was leading 15-10 in the second game before she came back 17-17. I think I was playing a little defensively there. I should have tried to control the points a bit more. I also think I can improve on my net play," she says.

She has another couple of months to work on those skills as she

prepares for the Uber Cup in May. While the squad hasn't yet been named, it would seem that Anmol had shown enough potential to guarantee a place in the team. But her goals are even higher. "I want to be a world champion some day, and I hope I can be on the podium at the 2028 Olympics," she says.

Anmol might be her toughest critic, but while she continues to hone her skills, there's one aspect in which at least her father believes she's unlikely to change much.

"She has always been a very happy-go-lucky girl. She's always pulling pranks. Like, when she comes back from her training, she will come from the back gate and then hug me from behind just to scare me. Even when she wins a match or a tournament, she'll expect a reward like a meal from a restaurant. But in

particular, she will demand chocolate ice cream. Because that is something she's not allowed to eat generally," he says.

A cheat meal was her reward for the Asian Team Championship gold as well. "After the tournament, we went out for lunch. We didn't eat ice cream, but we had boba tea. I've had it before, but the one we had in Malaysia was really tasty," she says.

As the baby of the squad, Anmol only got to enjoy herself, but now that she's back in India and is being hailed as one of the biggest prospects in Indian badminton, the roles have been reversed.

"All my friends and teammates are teasing me a little bit. They are saying you are a big player; you won't speak to us anymore, so, at least give us a party. I'll have to give a pizza party at least," she says.